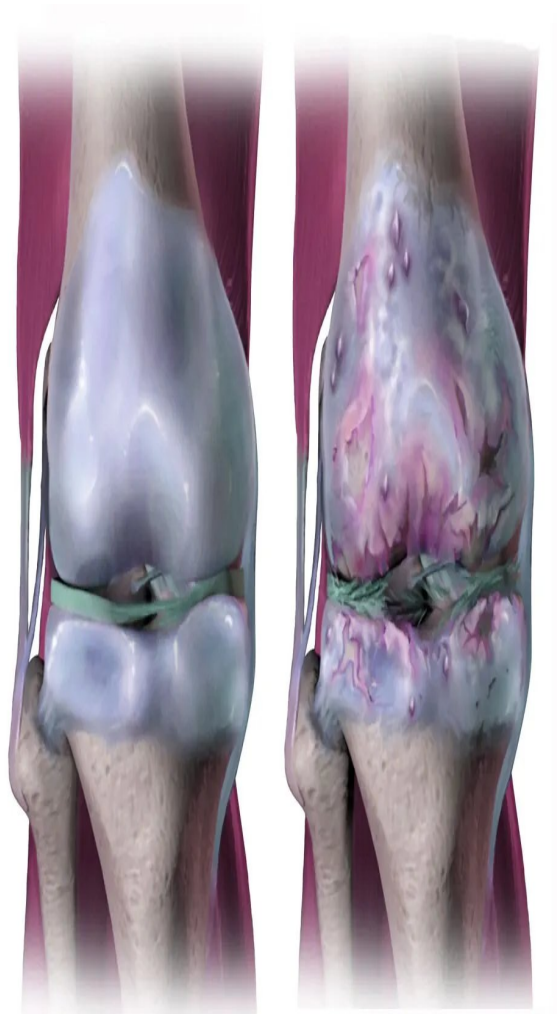


Sarcopenia: Muscle Loss and How to Combat It

Sarcopenia, the age-related loss of muscle mass and strength, is common but not inevitable. Here's how to recognise it and fight back.

By **Maxwell** · Reviewed by **Maxwell** (First Contact Practitioner, HCPC PH128483, CSP Member) · 2026-06-21 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Sarcopenia is the progressive loss of muscle mass, strength, and function that occurs with ageing. While some muscle loss is a normal part of growing older, sarcopenia refers to a more significant decline that can affect mobility, balance, and independence. Muscle mass typically begins to decline gradually starting around the 30s, with the rate of loss accelerating after age 60 if left unaddressed. The good news is that sarcopenia, even when advanced, responds remarkably well to resistance training at almost any age.



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What Is Sarcopenia?

Sarcopenia is not simply being weak or out of shape. It's a specific syndrome characterised by a progressive, generalised loss of skeletal muscle mass and strength that leads to physical disability, poor quality of life, and a high risk of adverse health outcomes including falls, fractures, and loss of independence.

Most people lose approximately 3-8% of their muscle mass per decade starting around age 30. This loss accelerates after age 60, with some people losing 20-30% of their muscle mass between the ages of 50 and 80. This translates to lost strength, reduced endurance, and difficulty with everyday activities like climbing stairs, carrying shopping, or even rising from a chair.

The mechanisms behind sarcopenia are complex. Reduced physical activity is a major driver — our bodies are responsive to demand, and if muscles aren't regularly challenged, they shrink. Hormonal changes, declining levels of growth hormone and testosterone, contribute. Inadequate protein intake means the body lacks the building blocks to maintain muscle. Chronic inflammation associated with ageing damages muscle tissue.



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Recognising the Signs

Sarcopenia often develops gradually, making it easy to overlook in its early stages. Common signs include a noticeable decline in grip strength, difficulty rising from a chair without using your arms, a slower walking pace, reduced stamina during daily activities, and unintentional muscle shrinkage that may be visible in the arms or legs.

You might notice you tire more easily, that tasks requiring strength (opening jars, carrying bags, climbing stairs) have become more difficult, or that your clothes fit differently even though your weight hasn't changed. These can all be early signs of sarcopenia.

Grip strength is a particularly good indicator of overall muscle health and is often measured by healthcare providers as a screening tool. A significant decline in grip strength is often an early warning sign that more widespread muscle loss is occurring.



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What Causes Sarcopenia?

Sarcopenia results from a combination of factors: declining levels of growth hormone and testosterone with age, reduced physical activity, inadequate protein intake, chronic inflammation, and in some cases, underlying chronic disease. A sedentary lifestyle significantly accelerates muscle loss, which is part of why even modest increases in activity

can meaningfully slow the condition's progression.

Disease, injury, or prolonged periods of bed rest can rapidly accelerate sarcopenia. Someone who breaks a leg and is immobilised in a cast can lose significant muscle mass in just weeks. This is why maintaining activity and physical therapy during recovery from injury is so important.

Certain medical conditions, including cancer, chronic obstructive pulmonary disease, heart disease, and metabolic conditions, can contribute to accelerated muscle loss. Managing these underlying conditions is part of addressing sarcopenia.

The Power of Resistance Exercise

Resistance training is the single most effective intervention for combating sarcopenia. Unlike some age-related changes, muscle responds to strength training at virtually any age — studies have shown meaningful strength gains even in adults in their 80s and 90s who begin a structured resistance programme. Exercises using resistance bands, light weights, or bodyweight movements like sit-to-stands, performed two to three times weekly, can rebuild and maintain muscle mass effectively.

The mechanism is straightforward: when you challenge muscles with resistance, they respond by rebuilding and getting stronger. This happens regardless of age. Someone starting strength training at 70, 80, or even 90 will see improvements in strength and muscle mass, though the rate of gain may be somewhat slower than in younger people.

A typical effective programme includes exercises targeting major muscle groups: legs (squats, sit-to-stands, leg presses), chest and back (rows, chest press), and arms. Resistance can come from light dumbbells, resistance bands, or even bodyweight. The key is consistency and gradually increasing the challenge over time.

Nutrition's Role in Preserving Muscle

Adequate protein intake is essential for maintaining muscle mass, and many older adults consume less protein than their bodies need to support muscle repair and growth. Research suggests older adults need approximately 1.0-1.2 grams of protein per kilogram of body weight daily — roughly 20-25% higher than younger adults.

Spreading protein intake across meals, rather than concentrating it at one meal, may improve how effectively the body uses it for muscle maintenance. Including protein at breakfast, lunch,

and dinner — rather than having large amounts at one meal — appears to be more effective for preserving muscle.

Vitamin D also plays a supporting role in muscle function, and many older adults have low vitamin D levels due to limited sun exposure or reduced dietary intake. Supplementation may improve muscle function if levels are low.

Reversing Sarcopenia

The important message is that sarcopenia is not an inevitable, unstoppable part of ageing. A combination of regular resistance exercise and adequate protein intake can meaningfully slow, halt, or even partially reverse muscle loss at almost any age. Starting sooner rather than later is better, but it's rarely too late to benefit.

Some studies have shown that older adults who hadn't exercised in years could regain significant muscle mass and strength within 8-12 weeks of beginning a resistance programme. Others have shown that people in their 90s can still build muscle with appropriate training.

If you're concerned about muscle strength or function, a doctor or physical therapist can assess your status and help build an appropriate plan. This article is for general information only and is not a substitute for professional medical advice.

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Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about sarcopenia: muscle loss and how to combat it?

Short answer: Sarcopenia is the progressive loss of muscle mass, strength, and function, commonly appearing as a significant decline with ageing. It results from reduced physical activity, hormonal changes, inadequate protein intake, and chronic inflammation. Recognising signs like reduced grip strength or slower walking pace is key. Resistance training and sufficient protein intake are effective in combating and even reversing sarcopenia.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team

promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk